HERMES.
FREE API FIRST.

Nous + OpenRouter + FreeLLMAPI. Local when useful. Paid only by choice.

HERMES IS THE AGENT

It uses approved tools, models, skills and scheduled jobs.

NOUS + OPENROUTER

Start with an eligible, explicitly free model route.

FREELLMAPI IS THE ROUTER

Combine only the upstream allowances you actually have.

FREE ≠ EVERY SERVICE

Trials, earned credits and paid subscriptions are different.

INSTALL THE AGENT FIRST.

A free cloud API does not require a powerful GPU.

1 / USE THE OFFICIAL INSTALLER

Choose the correct desktop or CLI package for your operating system.

hermes-agent.nousresearch.com

```
hermes setup
hermes model
hermes doctor
```

- **TEST A REAL TOOL CALL**

  In an empty folder, ask it to list files without modifying anything.

Keep command approvals on. Review tool backends: free chat does not make search, images or cloud browsers free.

NOUS PORTAL HAS A FREE PLAN.

Free models only. $0 monthly credits is not a budget for paid models.

- **CREATE / SIGN INTO YOUR ACCOUNT**

  Choose the Free plan, then use Hermes model setup → Nous Portal.

CHECKED STARTER MODEL

poolside/laguna-s-2.1:free

API BASE URL

https://inference-api.nousresearch.com/v1

Use exact free IDs from the current catalog. Hosted tools have separate entitlements. Never assume every Portal model or tool is free.

portal.nousresearch.com

Free plan and current paid options →

ADD ANOTHER FREE API ROUTE.

Create your own key. Enter it only in trusted local provider settings.

openrouter.ai/settings/keys

SELECT A VERIFIED FREE MODEL

nvidia/nemotron-3-ultra-550b-a55b:free

OR USE THE FREE ROUTER

openrouter/free selects eligible free models. Do not confuse it with openrouter/auto.

- **KEEP EVERY FALLBACK FREE / LOCAL**

  A free main model plus a paid backup can still generate a bill.

Free quotas are shared across your account. When exhausted: wait, use local, or ask — do not evade limits.

Browse current free models →

ONE LOCAL API. YOUR OWN ALLOWANCES.

The self-hosted router does not manufacture free provider credits.

- **INSTALL THE RIGHT PROJECT**

  Use tashfeenahmed/freellmapi. Choose its supported desktop or Docker/server path.

- **ADD LEGITIMATE UPSTREAM KEYS**

  Use its local Keys UI. Enable and test eligible free models only.

CONNECT HERMES AS A CUSTOM ENDPOINT

Usual server URL: http://127.0.0.1:3001/v1. Use the unified gateway key — not the admin token.

Audit the gateway chain AND Hermes fallbacks. auto is only as free as its enabled routes. The optional live catalog subscription is paid.

Correct source and installation guide →

KNOW WHAT “FREE” MEANS.

Installed, connected and free are three different claims.

ELIGIBLE FREE ALLOWANCES

Groq, Gemini, Mistral and Cloudflare: check your exact plan, model, limits and data terms.

EARNED CREDITS / TRIALS

Pollinations Quest Pollen is finite. NVIDIA, Cerebras and Cohere have trial/evaluation terms.

DO NOT LABEL THESE FREE APIs

NanoGPT: web-free is not API-free. Cheaper Inference: paid. HF hosted free accounts: no included credits.

The full handbook includes signup links, API setup, entitlement checks and the installed-provider inventory.

LOCAL WHEN USEFUL. NO SILENT SPEND.

Private work needs local inference, local auxiliaries and no cloud fallback.

- **OPTIONAL LOCAL MODELS**

  Hermes Settings → Providers → Local Models. Download only a model that fits your hardware.

- **PIN BACKGROUND WORK**

  Audit cron pins, workers, subagents, compression, titles, vision and external tools.

PAID REQUIRES PERMISSION

Only an explicit choice or a bounded, preauthorized exception. Enforce budgets outside the prompt.

Jev is optional. A confidence score is not spending permission, and a hosted decision API can itself cost money.

TEST THE ROUTE. SHARE THE GUIDE.

A model claiming it is free is not evidence. Check actual routing and activity.

START WITH A HARMLESS TEST

Ask for a real read-only tool call. Inspect the served model, provider, quota and cost before automation.

Hermes docs and setup

Nous Portal Free plan

OpenRouter free model catalog

FreeLLMAPI project and install

FULL HANDBOOK + AI SETUP KIT

The share pack includes the complete linked PDF, copyable Markdown, image cards and sharing caption.

Never share keys, auth.json or private logs. Free cloud sends data to third parties; quotas and terms can change.